

What else to watch: *Un Chien Andalou* (1929, p.330) ■ *L'Avventura* (1960) ■ *La Dolce Vita* (1960, pp.160–65) ■ *Pierrot le Fou* (1965) ■ *The Shining* (1980, p.339) ■ *The Draughtsman's Contract* (1982) ■ *Open Your Eyes* (1997) ■ *Flowers of Shanghai* (1998)



This famous scene, in which the figures cast shadows but the trees do not, highlights the dreamlike, unreal nature of *Last Year at Marienbad*, and of much of Resnais' work generally.

The midnight chime that opens the movie is heard again at the end, echoing life's endless loop of acceptance and rejection, as X is rejected by A, and vice versa. As A says, "I have never stayed so long anywhere." Famously, Robbe-Grillet has stated that "the entire story of *Marienbad* happens neither in two years nor in three days, but exactly in one hour and a half"—that is, the time span of the movie.

Last Year at Marienbad has been interpreted in various ways, in terms of Jungian or Freudian psychology, and using poststructuralist analysis, but agreement on the movie's meaning is rare. Nevertheless, for many critics, it is a high point of the experimental fervor that drove the French New Wave to expand the possibilities and goals of filmmaking in the late 1950s and early 1960s, and it remains influential to this day. ■

“I must **have you** alive. **Alive**, as you have already been **every evening**, for **weeks**, for **months**.”

X / Last Year at Marienbad

unsettled, unsure whether it's all in X's head, or A's. The movie is a continual interplay of reality and illusion. In one famous scene, shot on an overcast day when the trees cast no shadows, the people arranged elegantly along an avenue all project long shadows across the ground. To achieve this effect, actors' shadows were painted onto the ground.

Story of a persuading

Resnais said that the movie's effects were an attempt to recreate the way the mind works, while Robbe-Grillet insisted that viewers will get lost if they look for a linear narrative. "The whole film, as a

matter of fact, is the story of a persuading [une *persuasion*]," according to Robbe-Grillet. "It deals with a reality which the hero creates out of his own vision."

There is no sense of time or the story moving forward—the plot, such as it is, is circular and repetitive.

Delphine Seyrig, playing A, was memorably costumed for the role by fashion legend Coco Chanel.

